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Section Title(S)

3. The Diviner in Action • a. Reserved Areas • b. Sexual Restraints • c. Food/Work • c. Speech

After a further course of training the Great Passing Out follows. Another white goat is killed. The master requests the apprentice's ancestors to return with her to her kraal. The diviner's guild which has been invited accompanies the graduand home. There, too, a goat is killed in the apse of the Great Hut, incense is burned and the bile sprinkled about. A beast is killed to thank the ancestors. Its bile is poured over the new diviner. The guild performs a dance in the pen, then eating and drinking follow. Dances continue through the night. The next morning the visitors rub themselves with ash so that no fat is carried away on their bodies. It would kill the spirit so recently implanted in the newly-fledged diviner. She is given presents by her affines 'to make fast her ties of relationship' (Asmus:91f).

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3. The Diviner in Action

observes more abstentions and avoidances than the novice, but only intermittently, i.e., only at the time of a consultation.

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Magicians And Diviners

a. Reserved Areas

When engaged in a divination the practitioner must have no contact with his family or friends, neighbours or strangers (Za). He shares his hut with the spirits during a consultation or Smelling Out. He shuts himself up in his hut, even if it is only to take snuff to induce yawning, sneezing, shuddering in himself or to strew incense and snuff on his head. Preferably he should retire to the hills, but unlike the time when he was in the grip of the 'diviner's disease', he must not sleep there; he would lose the spirit(s) again. When preparing medicines — he chews roots and blows his medicated breath over his sticks or bones — and while waiting for a revelation, he must not leave his hut nor see any callers, not even his own kin (Za). Only his assistant may attend him. He must not leave his medicine pots standing or his medicines lying about (Za). They must be kept in a safe place. If he trains apprentices, the water required for the foaming medicines must be brought by immature children who have not yet acquired *isiThunzi* (shadow, dignity: Asmus:84/5). He must maintain contact with his spirit: he cannot omit to speak to it every day, to offer it a special beast once a year. He cannot dance to any other song than that which was revealed to him in dream or trance. This is both interdict (Za) and respectful restraint (HI) toward the spirit.

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The diviner's dress indicates his special character. He wears goatskin braces, carries an oxtail whisk and a gnu or eland tail. He returns from his wanderings with his body painted with clay or ochre. He cannot paint his back (Za); it must be done by his assistant. And since he may not touch either water or fat he does not wash or anoint himself when officiating. A diviner does not wear a head-ring, a woman diviner no top-knot (Callaway: 1868:262; Krige).

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Magicians And Diviners

b. Sexual Restraints

When expecting clients a diviner may not have sexual intercourse. Nor may he sleep with his wife the night before a Smelling Out (Asmus:98); he would become a fool (*isiThutha*, *isiPhukuphuku*). It is not that his efficiency is impaired, but the medicines are weakened. Yet some informants argue that sexual contact in such circumstances would make him unclean (*Ngcolile*) and cause him to lose self-respect (*ukuziPhatha kahle*). (121) thinks there is a wide-spread disregard of this interdict, for many diviners complain of a sickness in which the whole body is painful! It is sent by the spirit of the

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shoulder blade but can be cured by the administration of suitable counter-medicines.

General Sex Restrictions

c. Speech

The speech restrictions resemble respectful restraints in bi-polar social relations. Yet in this context most informants call them taboos (Za). The diviner does not greet his client first, as is normal practice for the family head (a case of ritual inversion). Especially reprehensible is the shaking of hands (Za). A diviner must not talk in advance about the solution of a problem in hand. He should not chatter about irrelevancies but remain concentrated. The use of a harsh, accusing, scolding voice is deprecated. (This is a definite prohibition, not a piece of advice in the Dale Carnegie manner.) Jokes, attempts to raise a laugh are out of place, they break the solemnity of the occasion. The diviner must not get angry with his bones or sticks 231 or reprimand his spirit before his clients. In giving his findings he should avoid ordinary language; the diviner sings out his findings or employs a go-between. Signs of nervousness, like fidgeting with the fingers, are suppressed (Za). The diviner should remain immovable and inscrutable. It is feared that too many gestures will reveal his intentions too soon. The smelling out of a wizard is valid only if done with gnu or eland tail.

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